

Trump’s team united by criticism of COVID steps

Nominees were outspoken, though reasons differed

By Tal Kopan
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Donald Trump’s first term ended amid the tumult of COVID-19’s emergence. Now, four years later, the pandemic’s repercussions are shaping his second.

Trump has stocked his incoming administration with figures who were loudly critical of protective measures against the spread of the virus, many implemented or encouraged by his team during his first term. Among a diverse array of nominees — from public health to law enforcement and national security — criticism of anti-COVID measures is often the commonality. Though the reasons behind their discontent frequently differed, none of them appeared to blame Trump, and they in fact rallied together under his banner in protest of COVID-era policies.

Even this long after the restrictions lifted and the threat to public health diminished, the distrust and frustration fomented by protective measures like lockdowns and masking requirements continue to reverberate through conservatism.

“The echo of COVID-19, I think, was a great reset in the national political mind,” said Representative

COVID, Page A6



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Tim Meeh, 72, and his wife, Jill McCullough, have been working North Family Farm in Canterbury, N.H., for half a century.

FOR AGING FARMERS, A GROWING CONCERN

Getting a family member to take over a maple operation is no easy thing

By Amanda Gokee
GLOBE STAFF

CANTERBURY, N.H.
Tim Meeh is still farming the same land where he was born, near the crest of a hill blanketed with a sugar maple forest.

For 50 years, Meeh and his wife, Jill McCullough, have coaxed maple trees to grow in the acidic soil, building North Family Farm into a business that has sustained their family.

Now 72, Meeh and McCullough won’t be able to farm forever, and the farm’s future is yet to be determined. Like many aging farmers in the region, the couple is facing the thorny problem of how to hand off their life’s

work — a complicated task involving money, family, and a deep connection to the land.

Farmers around New England are facing this precarious situation in the top region for maple syrup production in the country. The transition to the next generation will determine how much of the region’s agricultural roots — and identity — remains intact.

Maple farming is part of a multimillion-dollar industry in New Hampshire but many farms are on the brink of disappearing. As of 2022, more than 40 percent of New Hampshire farmers are over 65 years old, while only 7 percent are under 35, according to the latest Census of Agriculture by the US Department of Agriculture. And some small farms are struggling to stay in business.

“There’s no easy answer, and it won’t come immediately,” said McCullough. She raised her two sons, now 38 and 40, on North Family Farm. Although both help out, she and Meeh said neither has volunteered to take over the business.

Seth Wilner, an agricultural business management specialist at the University of New Hampshire Cooperative Extension, said there has been a strong increase over the past 10 to 15 years in aging New Hampshire farmers looking to retire.

At stake is more than the fate of an individual farm, Wilner said. If farms go out of business, related sectors are also weakened, such as big-animal veterinarians and tractor

FARMERS, Page A7

FRANCIS BELLOTTI 1923-2024



GLOBE FILE/1980

Francis Bellotti was never elected governor, but he made his mark as a longtime attorney general.

In courtroom and on the trail, a fighter

By Joseph P. Kahn
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Francis X. Bellotti, a fierce, powerful Democrat who fell short in his three bids for governor yet wielded broad influence as a corruption-fighting attorney general in Massachusetts, died Tuesday. He was 101.

For seven often-tumultuous decades, Mr. Bellotti was a commanding presence on the city’s and state’s legal and political scenes. As the state’s top law enforcement official in the 1970s and ’80s, he was credited with professionalizing an office that became a model for attorneys general across the country and a training ground for dozens of future Massachusetts judges.

Operating in private law for many years thereafter, he became a well-regarded problem solver and rainmaker. In yet another professional role, serving as vice chairman and director of the Arbella Insurance Group, he became known as a powerhouse insurance executive.

“He was always there for us as a guiding light in all our endeavors,” his son Peter, a defense lawyer and former Middlesex assistant district attorney, said in a statement re-

BELLOTTI, Page C9

‘What happened . . . is attributable to one man, Ralph de la Torre.’

GOVERNOR MAURA HEALEY

Healey says she did all she could on Steward

By Chris Serres, Elizabeth Koh, and Liz Kowalczyk
GLOBE STAFF

Governor Maura Healey defended her record Tuesday on Steward Health Care, saying she “did all that I could do” to address the now-bankrupt hospital chain’s collapse, which a recent



FOLLOW-UP

Globe Spotlight Team investigation found was enabled by years of lax state scrutiny.

Healey placed the blame

for the hospital chain’s subpar care and massive financial losses on former Steward chief executive Ralph de la Torre, who resigned in October and is now a focus of a federal corruption investigation.

“What happened with Steward is attributable to one man, Ralph de la Torre, and those around him who enabled and furthered greed and corruption,” Healey said in an interview following an unrelated news conference Tuesday.

Her comments came as federal and state lawmakers redoubled calls for greater

STEWARD, Page A7

Legislative leaders said they’ve reached a deal on a bill targeting the state’s opioid epidemic, but a controversial proposal to allow for safe injection sites has been dropped. **B1.**

Chef Barbara Lynch will be allowed to sell her remaining restaurants but must put the proceeds into escrow. **B5.**

Luigi Mangione has now been charged with mur-

der as an act of terrorism in the slaying of a chief executive. **A2.**

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu vowed Israeli troops will stay in Syria indefinitely. **A3.**



The gift of cookies

There’s nothing more comforting, for the baker or the recipient. At left, Brown Butter Blondies. **G1, G3.**

In the Boston-area Restaurant Awards, Devra First hails some of the many standouts on the food scene this year. **G1.**

Coming down

Wednesday: Some sun, then rain late. High 45-50. Low 36-41.

Thursday: Clearing, still mild. High 42-47. Low 26-31.

Sunrise: 7:08 Sunset: 4:13

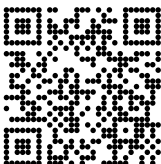
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VOL. 306, NO. 171

Suggested retail price
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